

Council of Trent

The Counter-Reformation was conceived in the Italian Alpine town of Trent, then under Austrian Habsburg rule. Here, in the cathedral, the Church Council met in 1545–47, 1551–52, and finally in 1562–63, to reform the doctrines and practices of the church to meet the threat posed by the Protestant Reformation.

Pope Paul III convened the first session of the Council of Trent in 1545; the second and third sessions were convened by Julius III and Pius IV.

Catholic cardinals and bishops and leading Catholic theologians attended the council; no Protestants attended.

IDEA**COUNTER-REFORMATION**

The Counter- (or Catholic) Reformation set out to challenge the appeal of the new Protestant churches by reforming and remodeling the Catholic Church, drawing on a great mass of reformist sentiment and enthusiasm within the church that had been building up since the late 15th century. It strengthened the spiritual institution of the papacy, reformed old and formed new religious orders, most notably the Jesuits, who set up schools and missions to preach Catholic virtues, and clarified church doctrines. Congregations were lured back into church through increased use of ornament and spectacle, best personified by the glorious new churches in the Baroque style in Austria and Italy—the spectacular ceiling of St. Ignatius Church in Rome (right), dating from around 1707, shows the missionary work of the Jesuits.



and not the Latin of the church—as the foundation of all preaching and teaching. Unlike Luther, however, who believed in the political subordination of the church to the state, Calvin preached that church and state should act together to create a “godly society”

in which religious beliefs and strict codes of conduct should shape every aspect of daily life. Calvinism took hold in Scotland, the Netherlands, and in large parts of France, where followers were known as Huguenots, and in areas across the German states, Bohemia, and Transylvania. Calvinism also inspired the Puritan movement in England and, later, North America, whose members wished to purify the Anglican church of its remaining Catholic elements, notably the authority of bishops and the “popish” adornment of church vestments, ornaments, and music.

Church began to reform itself, drawing on a groundswell of internal calls for church reform that long predated the emergence of Luther.

Meeting in three sessions at Trent in the Italian Alps from 1545–63, the Catholic Church initiated a Counter-Reformation (see box). The Catholic Counter-Reformation succeeded in its aims, strengthening Catholicism both theologically and politically, although a more authoritarian orthodoxy was instituted. Poland, Austria, and Bavaria now became solidly Catholic. But while Germany remained largely at peace, the strong Calvinist (Huguenot) presence in France prompted a lengthy religious war that was only ended with the granting of religious toleration in the Edict of Nantes in 1598. By the end of the century, perhaps 40 percent of Europe’s population followed one or other of the reformed beliefs.

**St. Bartholomew's Day Massacre**

The French wars of religion reached a bloody climax on St. Bartholomew's Day (August 24) 1572, when the French regent, Catherine de Medici, authorized the massacre of about 200 Huguenot leaders meeting in Paris for her daughter's wedding. Catholic mobs then went on a rampage, killing thousands more Huguenots.

Reformation in Europe

By 1600 the religious map of Europe was largely settled. Lutheran churches were well established in Germany and Scandinavia, and Calvinist churches in Switzerland, the Netherlands, and Scotland. The Anglican religion was established in England and Wales. France, Spain, Portugal, Italy, southern Germany, and Poland were largely Catholic, although Calvinist beliefs were strong in south and west France, while Austria was evenly split.

KEY

Catholic
Protestant
Frontiers 1590

**AFTER**

The impact of the Reformation continued to be felt well into the 17th century.

WARS OF RELIGION

Religious fervor continued to inflame European politics. The **30 Years War 262–63** of 1618–49 began as a religious conflict between Catholic Austria and Protestant Bohemia (in the present-day Czech Republic), although in its later stages it became a political struggle for supremacy between France and the equally Catholic nations of Spain and Austria. The **Wars of the Three Kingdoms** in the British Isles (including the English Civil War **264–65**), which developed after 1639, were largely caused by Charles I's emphasis on an Anglican church, which stressed ritual and the importance of the sacraments, actions that were regarded as “popish” by the Calvinist Scots and Charles' enemies among the puritan English. Not until the signing of the **Treaty of Westphalia** ending the 30 Years War in 1648 did **religion become secondary to the state** in European politics.